

WILLIAM
BISSELL

42, TEXTILE ENTREPRENEUR
MD, FABINDIA
INITIAL INVESTMENT \$38,000
TURNOVER IN 2008 Rs 260 crore

WHEN EARTHY MET SAVVY

His earliest memories are of bales of fabric and their smell as he played around them. For a young William Bissell, waiting to meet his father John after school, to go for a swim, these are memories of a "nice time, a relaxed time". "At that time, Fabindia was mostly an export business," he remembers. Then it moved to the flagship South Delhi store. "That's when, in the 1980s, I became aware that we were also into retailing because people would come in," he says. But things have changed. Fabindia used to be an export business founded by his visionary father in 1960. John came to India to work as a consultant for the Ford Foundation and develop India's export potential in the emerging textile industry. Founding shareholders comprised a group of family and friends that put in \$38,000 as the initial capital.

Now the name is synonymous with a brand that has given handloom a new weave, with a chain of 97 stores across the country. Its transformation though, has a lot to do with Bissell's own metamorphosis. When Bissell, now managing director of Fabindia, returned from Wesleyan University, US, joining the business was not an option. "I was focused on working on cooperatives," he says. "I always thought businesses were exploitative." So, he went to Rajasthan and two-and-half years later realised that cooperatives was not the way to go. In 1993, Bissell's father fell ill and that's "when I really got involved," he says. "I felt a responsibility, but didn't think that I would be good at business. You can't be good at something you look down upon".

But Fabindia is not a traditional entrepreneurial venture. It sources its products from more than 15,000 craftsmen and artisans from all over the country and supports traditional crafts, providing sustainable employment. But before this, a crucial change was necessary. "I didn't see a place for export in the future," Bissell says. The export industry would become a two-player business with no place for intermediaries like Fabindia. "So I thought, 'what do we have going for us'?" he says. "We had some recognition and we had a product, so it was on the basis of this that we took a bet. It was that leap of faith all entrepreneurs

have to take," he says. It changed the company around, giving it a unique identity.

For Bissell, it was this distinctiveness, the unwillingness to dilute the ethos that was the key to Fabindia's success. "It's about realising that you don't want to be a restaurant that does all kinds of cuisine," he says. That's why diversity and innovation are keywords to Fabindia's success. As is the company's ability to reinvent itself, whether through the apparel line or the introduction of organic food, furniture and jewellery. "But we work within a spectrum. We don't do synthetic furniture as that's not our mandate. It's not our job and that weakens your core," he says. Diversifying was not a conscious decision. While jewellery was a conventional business idea, organic food was where the leadership role of the brand came in. There was a lacuna in the market. "And though people have taken a long time to warm up to it," he says, "now every store has dedicated customers for organics."

Fabindia has also made its presence felt on the international shores through its six stores in Dubai, Bahrain, Doha and Rome. Bissell's idealistic dream as a young man also seems to be in progress. Last year, Fabindia started Artisans Micro Finance that creates community-owned company allowing craftspeople to own equity in the company. And Fabindia will just grow bigger over the next year or so. "It will be the beginning of a great innovative process," he says. Yet, he holds his cards close to his chest. The current market scenario has made him wary. A true entrepreneur, according to Bissell, is a person who would have creative curiosity, with the ability to think in multiple dimensions, who has a certain amount of restlessness, a vision and is a great convincer. He could be describing himself.

by Chitra Subramanyam

SUCCESS MANTRA

Change, adapt and have a real commitment, with an ability to introspect and be open to criticism

role MODEL

"Saurabh Mehta, a businessman in Mumbai, has been my constant mentor. I have gained a lot from him."

turning POINT

When his father fell ill, Bissell finally chose to lead Fabindia, something he'd never dreamt of

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